

Legacy & Next Step

Character **First**

SCIENTIFIC FOUNDATION — EVIDENCE PYRAMID

Systematic Review Henriksen et al. (2020) — review of 44 studies on talent environments in sport: end-of-season sessions with explicit reflection on values, contribution, and intentions significantly increase identity development and long-term sport participation. *British Journal of Sports Medicine*.

Longitudinal study End-of-season reflection on personal growth is associated with higher intrinsic motivation the following season.

Theoretical framework Seligman (2011) — PERMA model: meaning and accomplishment are the two most underestimated components of well-being in adolescents. Conscious reflection on contribution is an evidence-based strategy for activating both.

GUIDING THE CLOSING SESSION

- 1 Begin with a look back. Bring the Month 1 worksheet (the Three Words). Have players compare: "Are you still that person? Have you grown?" This creates a powerful sense of progression.
- 2 Read the Invisible Contributions that players wrote throughout the season (month 5). Do this by name, after the writer's permission. This is an emotional highlight of the program.
- 3 The letters to themselves are folded and sealed. You keep them as coach and return them at the first session of next season. This ritual has great symbolic value.
- 4 Close with a closing ceremony. Each player says one thing they learned about themselves this season. Not about basketball. About character.

COACH TIPS FOR THIS THEME

Tip 1: Write a letter to your future self as a coach too. Share part of it. "What do I hope to do better as a coach next season?" This closes the program in the spirit in which it began: vulnerability as strength.

Tip 2: At the end of the season, send a personal message to each player with one specific observation of their growth. Not an athletic achievement. A moment of character that you witnessed. This is the most powerful feedback you can ever give.

Tip 3: Use the Month 8 intentions as input for your conversations at the start of next season. "You wrote that you wanted to be the first voice more often. How did that go?" Continuity makes the program sustainable.

△ Make sure the closing session gets enough time. Minimum 45 minutes. This is not an additional activity but the highlight of 8 months of work. Give it the space it deserves.

CLOSING SESSION TIMING

- ☐ Look back at Month 1 worksheets: 10 minutes
- ☐ Reading Invisible Contributions: 10 minutes
- ☐ Individual completion of Month 8 worksheet: 15 minutes
- ☐ Sealing and handing over letters to coach: 5 minutes
- ☐ Closing ceremony: one thing learned about character: 10 minutes
- ☐ Closing words from the coach: 5 minutes